Group 6 — Continental Realists: you cannot defend the Arctic against the Americans, only with them

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Our position: Here is the uncomfortable arithmetic. The United States has nuclear submarines under the Arctic ice today; Canada will have diesel ones in 2034. NORAD, the thing that actually watches the northern sky, is a joint command with an American general at the top. Pretending Canada can stare down Washington over the Passage is theatre. The grown-up move is to settle the Passage dispute on our terms *now*, while we still have leverage, in exchange for binding American recognition and shared defence. Greenland just showed how.

Briefing

The Greenland crisis is this group's case study. In January 2026, President Trump said he was open to using military force to acquire Greenland and that the US would own it "one way or another"; officials threatened action "within weeks" (Wikipedia, Hands off Greenland protests). Nine months later, the United States, Denmark and Greenland signed a defence agreement in September 2026 that expands US military access to specified areas while reaffirming Danish sovereignty and Greenlanders' right to decide their own future (The Walrus, Oct. 2026; IBTimes, Oct. 26, 2026). Trump then called it the greatest real estate deal in history, even though no sovereignty changed hands. The Walrus drew the lesson that Trump can be made to retreat if you draw clear lines and then give him something to call a win.

Canada and the US are already more integrated than the rhetoric suggests. Canada is pouring roughly $28 billion over 20 years into NORAD modernization, a *joint* system (Economy.ac, Aug. 2026). The ICE Pact of 2024 pools Canadian, American and Finnish shipyards to build icebreakers (The Walrus, Sept. 2026). Operation NANOOK-TUUGAALIK 2026 had US, French and Danish ships operating in Canadian Arctic waters alongside HMCS *Robert Hampton Gray* from August to October (Economy.ac, Oct. 27, 2026). The US 2026 National Defense Strategy describes Canada as having a vital role in defending North America, and a senior US Arctic commander said Canadian forces are becoming *more* important as Russia and China push north (Hashtag Investing, Oct. 2026).

The Passage dispute is also narrower than it looks. Washington's worry is not Canadian ownership; it is precedent. If the US concedes that an archipelago route is internal water, China cites it in the South China Sea and Russia on the Northern Sea Route. One analysis notes the US might quietly welcome a Canadian legal right to bar Russian and Chinese warships, so long as American vessels are not blocked (GeoGarage, Sept. 2026). That is a deal waiting to be written: recognize Canadian control and Canadian rules, guarantee US transit, and jointly keep everyone else out. A pro-American commentator put it less politely: Trump is not trying to annex Canada, he is telling Ottawa it cannot resent American interests in the Passage while depending on American defence (AOL / New York Post, 2026).

> "Everyone wants a Canadian answer to the Arctic. There isn't one. There is a North American answer, and the only question is whether Canada helps write it or has it written for us." — *Helen Marchetti, former NORAD deputy commander (Canadian)* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.